Appropriate Language Use

Tone by Relationship

Situation	Correct	Incorrect
Wife to Husband	Hi honey, how was your day? / Great, we got a lot done. And yours? / Fine, but stressful. Pass me that magazine, please.	Hello, how are you today? / I'm fine. Would you mind passing me the bread? / Certainly. Would you like some butter? / Yes, please.
Friend to Friend	Hi Charlie, can you give me a hand? / Sure, Peter. What's up? / I can't get this to work. / Why don't you try a screwdriver?	Hello Mr. Jones. May I ask you a question? / Certainly. How may I help you? / Do you think you could help me with this? / I'd be happy to help.
Subordinate to Superior	Good morning, Mr. Jones. May I ask you a question? / Certainly, how can I help you?	Good morning, Frank. I need a raise. / Do you really? Well, forget about it!
Superior to Subordinate	Excuse me, Peter. We seem to have a problem with the Smith account. / We'd better sit down and discuss it.	Hey Jack, what are you doing?! Get to work! / Hey, I'll take as much time as I need.
Coworker to Coworker	Hey, do you have a minute? I'm stuck on this report. / Sure, let me take a look. / Thanks, I owe you one.	I require your immediate assistance with this report. / I am otherwise engaged. / Kindly find someone else.
Customer to Staff	Excuse me, could you tell me where the milk is? / Of course, it's down the aisle on your right. / Thanks — is the bread down there too? / Yes, just past the eggs.	Where's the milk? / Over there.
Speaking to a Stranger	Pardon me. Do you think you could give me the time? / Certainly, it's twelve thirty. / Thank you very much. / Not at all — happy to help.	You! Tell me where the supermarket is. / There.
Candidate to Interviewer	Good morning. Thank you for seeing me — I'm here for the 10 o'clock interview.	Hi, I'm here for the interview. Where do I go?
Manager to Team	Team, please send your weekly reports by Friday 5 p.m. Thanks, everyone.	Where are the reports? I need them now!
Colleague on WeChat	Hey, are you free for five minutes? I have a quick question about the invoice.	Come to my desk. Immediately.
Customer Complaint	Excuse me, my order arrived damaged. Could you help me sort it out?	This is a joke! You people are useless!
Asking for Leave	Hi Ms Li, I'm not feeling well. May I take sick leave and work from home today?	Not coming in today lol.
Staff to Client	Good morning, Mr. Wang. Here is the updated proposal — please let me know your thoughts.	Here's the thing you wanted. Read it and get back to me.
Team Member to Manager	Hi Ms Li, I've finished the Q3 report. Could you take a look when you have time?	Report's done. Check it.

Situation	Correct	Incorrect
Receptionist to Guest	Good morning. May I have your name, and who are you here to see?	Who are you? Who do you want?

Which Register Is It? Colleagues / Staff to Management / Management to Staff / Inappropriate

Sentence	Answer
Hey, can I borrow your charger for ten minutes? My phone is about to die.	_____
Lunch at the noodle place downstairs? I'll order on the app while you finish up.	_____
Anyone want bubble tea? I'm putting in an order on Meituan.	_____
Could you take my 3 p.m. call for me? I have to step out for a delivery.	_____
What did you do last weekend?	_____
Excuse me, do you have a moment? I'd like to talk about my workload.	_____
Would it be possible to leave early on Friday? I have a doctor's appointment.	_____
Excuse me, could you help me with this report for a moment?	_____
Excuse me, would you mind lending me some cash for lunch? I forgot my wallet.	_____
I've been on this project for two years. Could we discuss a raise at some point?	_____
I'm afraid we've had some problems with your performance. Let's talk this afternoon.	_____
Could you finish the client deck before you leave today? It's for tomorrow's meeting.	_____
Your report was strong. Next time, add the numbers for Q3.	_____
We're moving the team meeting to 9:30 tomorrow. Please update your calendar.	_____
Please don't book meetings before 9 a.m. — the team needs time to plan the day.	_____
Hey, get over here now!	_____
Give me five bucks for lunch. I forgot to go to the bank.	_____
You are an extremely handsome young man. I'm sure you'll do well here.	_____
Listen, I'm going home early, so I can't finish the project until tomorrow.	_____
Did you see how much weight Li put on over the holiday?	_____